

MINECRAFT SERVER ECONOMY HANDBOOK

The Economy Guide

Keep the coins flowing and the prices fair.

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Online version: github.com/direkjames/economy-guide

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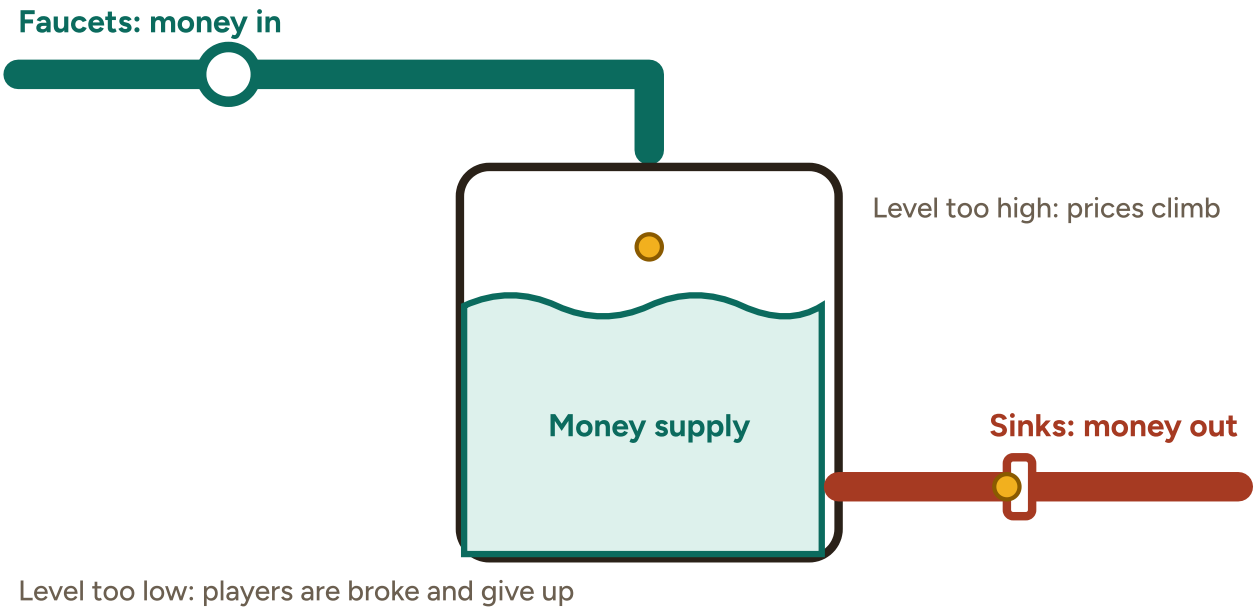
Start here

What an economy is, the rules that never change, and a plan to launch one.

How a server economy works

The five ideas behind every Minecraft economy, explained without jargon.

A server economy is a set of rules about how players earn coins, what coins can buy and how coins leave the game again. If you get those three things right, players feel rewarded and prices stay sane. If you get them wrong, the server drifts into one of two bad places: **inflation**, where coins are everywhere and worth nothing, or **deadlock**, where nobody can afford anything.



Your whole job: keep the level steady while the server grows.

The five ideas

1. Money is created and destroyed by the server

In real life, banks and governments control the money supply. In Minecraft, **you** do, through your plugins and settings. Whenever a plugin pays a player for mining, selling or voting, it creates coins out of nothing. Whenever a player pays for a plot, a repair or a tax, those coins vanish for good.

Money moving **between players** does not create or destroy anything. If Alex pays Sam 500 coins, the total stays the same. Only the server can change the total.

2. Faucets pour money in

A **faucet** is anything that creates new coins: jobs, selling items to a shop, quests, daily rewards, crates, vote rewards, bank interest and events. See the faucet catalogue.

3. Sinks drain money out

A **sink** is anything that permanently removes coins: taxes, fees, rent, repair costs, rank-up prices, cosmetics and shop prices. See the sink catalogue.

4. Balance is the whole game

If faucets are bigger than sinks, the total money keeps growing while the amount of stuff in the world stays the same. Every coin buys less. That is inflation. If sinks are bigger than faucets for long, players run out of money and quit.

> THE GOLDEN RULE
> Over a week, the money you destroy should be close to the money you create. About 80% to 100% is a healthy target for a settled server.

5. Players feel time, not numbers

A player does not care whether a diamond sword costs 500 or 5,000 coins. They care whether it takes **20 minutes** or **20 hours** to earn. Price everything in hours of effort, then pick the numbers that match. More on that in Pricing items.

Why economies break

PROBLEM	WHAT PLAYERS SEE	USUAL CAUSE
Inflation	Prices keep rising, old players are millionaires, new players are priced out	Faucets with no sinks, or an exploit
Deflation	Nobody has money, shops are empty, players quit	Sinks too big, rewards too small
Hoarding	Rich players sit on huge piles of coins with nothing to buy	No good things to spend money on
Monopoly	One player controls a key item or the market	No limits on buying or selling in bulk
Exploit loops	Someone becomes rich in a day	A recipe or shop price that lets you turn 100 coins into 120



> NUGGET SAYS
> Do not try to build the perfect economy on day one. Build a simple one, measure it every week and fix what drifts. The weekly checklist is made for exactly that.

Words you will see a lot

- **Money supply:** all the coins that exist right now, added up.
- **Faucet:** a way coins are created.
- **Sink:** a way coins are destroyed.
- **Inflation:** the same item costs more and more coins over time.
- **Velocity:** how fast coins change hands. High velocity means a busy market.

The glossary has the full list.

Where to go next

1. Read the golden rules for a one-page summary.
2. Follow the launch plan if you are setting up a new economy.
3. Already running? Open the health check and see how your server is doing today.

Golden rules

The rules of thumb to keep on one page. Everything else in the guide explains why they work.

Print this page or pin it in your staff channel. When you are not sure what to do, check it against these rules.

The rules

1. EVERY COIN THAT COMES IN NEEDS A WAY OUT
Never add a faucet without deciding which sink will balance it.

2. AIM FOR SINKS OF 80% TO 100% OF FAUCETS
Measured over a week, on a settled server. A brand-new server can run at 60% to 80% while players are still building up.

3. WATCH MONEY PER PLAYER, NOT TOTAL MONEY
Total money grows when more players join, and that is fine. What matters is the average per active player. Keep it within about 5% of last week once the server settles.

4. PRICE IN HOURS, NOT COINS
Decide what an hour of play should earn. Price every item as hours to obtain times that rate.

5. BUY PRICE MUST ALWAYS BE HIGHER THAN SELL PRICE
Admin shops should pay players 20% to 40% of what they charge. The gap is a built-in tax and it also blocks loops.

6. TEST EVERY LOOP BEFORE LAUNCH
If any chain of buying, crafting and selling ends with more coins than it started with, players will find it within a day.

7. ADD DIMINISHING RETURNS
The 1,000th item sold in a day should pay less than the first. Daily caps, falling prices or stock limits all work.

8. TAX LIGHTLY AND VISIBLY

2% to 5% on player trades. Small enough that nobody avoids it, big enough to matter over thousands of trades.

9. SINKS SHOULD FEEL LIKE SPENDING, NOT LOSING

Players accept paying for a plot, a cosmetic or an upgrade. They hate a hidden fee. Give each sink something to look at.

10. RICH PLAYERS NEED THINGS TO BUY

If a rich player has nothing worth buying, their money sits and the economy stalls. Add prestige sinks: cosmetics, large builds, titles and limited items.

11. HELP NEW PLAYERS, NEVER FEED THEM MONEY

Starter kits, early quests and cheap first goals work better than big starting balances.

12. MEASURE EVERY WEEK, CHANGE ONE THING AT A TIME

Write down the numbers. Change one lever. Wait a week. Then judge.

13. NEVER REBALANCE IN SECRET

Announce changes, give a short notice period and explain the reason. Silent nerfs destroy trust.

14. LOG EVERYTHING MONEY TOUCHES

Admin commands, big transfers, shop sales and plugin errors. You cannot fix what you cannot see.

15. KEEP STAFF OUT OF THE ECONOMY

Staff should never give themselves or friends money. Use a separate account for testing and log every admin command.

Numbers to remember

THING	STARTING POINT
Sinks as a share of faucets (settled server)	80% to 100%
Admin shop sell price vs buy price	20% to 40%
Player trade tax	2% to 5%
Auction listing or sale fee	3% to 10%
Bank interest	Small, capped, and only on a limited balance
Starting balance	About 30 to 60 minutes of early-game earnings
Weekly change in money per player	Within 5% when stable, up to 15% when young
Average balance	7 to 60 days of a normal player's income
Share of money held by the richest 10%	Under 50% is healthy, over 70% is a warning

STARTING POINTS, NOT LAWS

These are common, battle-tested ranges, not universal truths. Your server has its own player count, speed and style. Start here, measure and adjust.

When something looks wrong

1. Open the health check and find which number is off.
2. Read spotting inflation to find the cause.
3. Use the fixing playbook and pick the gentlest lever that works.

Launch plan

A step-by-step plan for setting up a new economy, or rebuilding one you already run.

Follow these steps in order. Each one links to the page with the detail. Skipping the early steps is the most common reason economies need a reset later.

1. **Decide what the economy is for.** Is money the main goal (a trading server), or a tool for buying upgrades? Write one sentence. Every later choice must serve it.
2. **Choose the currency.** One currency is simpler. A second, premium currency adds complexity, so only add it if you have a clear reason. See Currency.
3. **Set the hourly rate.** Decide what a normal hour of play should earn at the start, in the middle and late in the game. See Pricing items.
4. **Build the price list.** Price every sellable and buyable item from hours of effort. Fill in a spreadsheet, not the plugin, first.
5. **Run the loop test.** Check every recipe and shop pair for a chain that makes coins from nothing. See Stopping exploits.
6. **List your faucets and set their limits.** For each one, write down the maximum coins per player per hour. See Money in.
7. **List your sinks and make sure they are worth buying.** Plots, upgrades, cosmetics, ranks and fees. See Money out.
8. **Add taxes and fees.** Keep them simple and visible. See Taxes and fees.
9. **Plan the first week for new players.** Starter kit, first goals and a short list of cheap things to buy. See Fairness.
10. **Turn on logging and a weekly number sheet.** You need a baseline from day one. See Tracking the economy.
11. **Soft launch.** Test with staff and a few trusted players for a few days. Try to break it on purpose.
12. **Open the server, then review every week.** Use the weekly checklist.

What to prepare before day one

- A spreadsheet with items, buy prices, sell prices and hours to obtain.
- A written list of faucets and sinks, each with a limit.
- A plugin list that matches your needs. See Plugin ideas.
- A staff rule for money: who can use admin commands, and how they are logged.
- A plan for what happens if something breaks: pause shops, freeze transfers, roll back. See Fixing inflation.

If you already run a server

Do not rebuild everything at once. Run the health check first. Fix the biggest problem, wait a week, then fix the next.



NUGGET SAYS

Soft launch matters more than it sounds. Players find exploits in hours. If your first ten testers cannot break it, you are in good shape.

Design

Pick the currency, price every item and shape how fast players grow rich.

Currency design

One currency or two, how many decimals, what starting money to give, and what a coin should be worth.

One currency or two?

OPTION	GOOD FOR	WATCH OUT FOR
One currency	Most servers. Easy to explain and balance	Everything competes for the same coins
Two currencies (earned plus premium)	Servers with prestige items, seasonal rewards or crates	Two economies to balance, and conversion becomes an exploit

If you add a second currency, follow three rules:

1. It must be **earned**, not bought with the main currency at a fixed rate. A fixed exchange rate turns the weaker currency into a loophole.
2. It should buy things the main currency cannot: cosmetics, titles, convenience.
3. Cap how much of it a player can earn per day.

> REAL MONEY
> If your server sells ranks or perks for real money, keep them cosmetic or convenience only. Never sell main-currency coins for cash. It wrecks fairness, and Mojang's rules on selling gameplay advantages have changed over the years, so check the current Commercial Usage Guidelines before you sell anything.

Whole numbers or decimals?

Use whole numbers for most items and a single decimal for rates only if you must. Players find "12,450" easier than "12,450.37". Small decimals also cause rounding bugs when plugins split payments or apply percentages.

If your plugin allows decimals, test a 1% tax on a 1-coin trade. Many plugins round it to zero, which lets players avoid tax by trading in tiny pieces.

Scale: how big should a coin be?

Pick a scale where **one early hour pays a few hundred to a few thousand coins**. Smaller numbers feel cramped, and huge numbers such as billions look silly and risk overflow bugs.

SCALE	EARLY HOUR EARNS	FEEL
Small	50 to 200	Every coin matters. Hard to tune prices
Medium (recommended)	500 to 3,000	Comfortable range with room to grow
Large	10,000+	Impressive numbers, easy to lose track of

Starting balance

Give new players enough for **30 to 60 minutes of early-game progress**, not more. A large starting balance feeds alt-account abuse, because anyone can make ten accounts and collect ten gifts.

Better ways to help new players: a starter kit, a short chain of early quests and cheap first purchases. See Fairness.

What anchors the currency?

A currency needs something that gives it meaning. Choose an anchor and keep it stable:

- **A common item.** For example, "1 coin is about one stack of cobblestone's effort", or "100 coins is about 10 minutes of early work".
- **A rank or progression price.** If the first rank costs 10,000, then 10,000 is a meaningful milestone and everything else is measured against it.
- **A big goal.** Something only rich players can afford, like a prime plot or an expensive cosmetic.

Without an anchor, players have no idea whether 5,000 is a lot, and prices drift.

Use a treasury or not?

A **treasury** is a server account that collects taxes and fees. There are two ways to run it:

- **Burn it.** Coins are removed. This is a true sink.
- **Recycle it.** Coins go back out as event prizes or public projects. This is not a sink, it is a transfer. It can be great for community feel, but count it as a faucet when you measure.

Whichever you pick, be honest about it in your numbers. See Taxes and fees.

Checklist

- One main currency, a second only if there is a clear reason
- Whole numbers wherever possible
- Early hour earns a few hundred to a few thousand coins
- Starting balance equals 30 to 60 minutes of play
- A named anchor (item, rank price or big goal)

- A decision on burn versus recycle for tax money

Pricing items

How to give every item a fair price, why buying and selling must differ, and how to stop bulk selling from ruining it.

Start with time

The best pricing method is simple: **price = hours to obtain x what an hour is worth**.

1. Pick an hourly rate for the stage of the game (for example 1,500 coins per hour early on).
2. Time how long it really takes to get one stack of the item the normal way.
3. Multiply. That is your base value.

> **A WORKED PRICE**
> An early hour is worth 1,500 coins. A good player mines 2 stacks of coal in 20 minutes (one third of an hour). 2 stacks is 128 coal, so the value is 500 coins for 128 coal, or about 3.9 coins per coal. Round to 4.

Do this for a handful of **anchor items** (coal, iron, wheat, logs, a few drops). Price everything else by comparing it to those.

Rarity and convenience

Some items are worth more than the time they take. Add a multiplier:

REASON	MULTIPLIER ON THE TIME-BASED VALUE
Common and easy to get in bulk	x1
Useful for a major upgrade	x1.5 to x2
Rare drop or hard to reach	x2 to x4
Unique, limited or prestige	Whatever the market will bear, with a ceiling

Buy and sell must differ

An admin shop that buys and sells the same item at the same price creates no value for the server and invites exploits. Use a **spread**:

BUY PRICE (PLAYER PAYS)	SELL PRICE (PLAYER GETS)	SELL AS % OF BUY
100	25 to 40	25% to 40%

The gap is a built-in tax. It means players who craft, trade and hold items always lose a bit to the server, which is a gentle sink.

> CHECK EVERY PAIR
> For any item, the sell price must be less than the buy price. For any crafted item, the sell price of the result must be less than or equal to the total sell value of its ingredients. If not, you have built a money machine.

Control bulk selling

Selling at a flat price forever turns shops into faucets. Pick at least one control:

- **Daily cap per player.** For example, sell up to 2,000 cobblestone a day at full price.
- **Falling price.** Every item sold reduces the price a little, then it recovers over time.
- **Stock limits.** The shop only has so much to buy. When it is full, it stops paying.
- **Global demand.** Server-wide price moves with total sales. Good, but harder to tune.

See Formulas for ready-made falling-price formulas.

Dynamic prices

Dynamic pricing means prices move with supply and demand. It adds life, and it can also swing wildly. If you use it:

- Set a **floor** and a **ceiling** (for example 20% to 300% of base).
- Change slowly. A single big sale should not crash the price.
- Reset daily or weekly so one bad day does not stick.

Staff pricing checklist

- Base price from hours, not guesses
- Sell price at 20% to 40% of buy price
- No crafting loop returns more than it costs
- Bulk sales are capped or slow down
- Rare items cost more than their time alone
- A spreadsheet holds every price, so you can change it in one place



> NUGGET SAYS
> Put your prices in a spreadsheet first. When something is out of balance you can fix a formula in one place, instead of editing 400 lines in a config.

Progression and the wealth curve

How fast should players get rich? Shape the early, middle and late game so there is always a next goal.

Money is only interesting when there is something to aim for. Your job is to make sure a player always has a goal that is **just out of reach, but visible**.

The three stages

STAGE	HOURS PLAYED	PLAYER GOALS	WHAT THE ECONOMY SHOULD DO
Early	0 to 20	Tools, first base, first rank	Quick wins. Prices low, earnings steady
Middle	20 to 150	Upgrades, bigger builds, better gear	Choices matter. Real costs, real decisions
Late	150+	Prestige, collections, status	Big sinks. Cosmetics, titles, large plots, limited items

The wealth curve

A healthy economy has income that grows with time **but more slowly than prices of the things players want**. Plot your price ladder:

- First rank costs about 1 to 2 hours of early income
- Second rank costs about 3 to 5 hours
- Later ranks cost 10, 25, 60 hours and up

If the ladder is too flat, players finish it in a weekend. If it is too steep, they give up. Ask a few real players how long each step felt.

Catch-up and slow down

Two mechanics keep the gap between new and old players healthy:

Catch-up (for new players)

- Bonus rewards from early quests
- Small multipliers for the first X hours
- Cheap starter items that do not scale with wealth

Slow-down (for rich players)

- Costs that rise with wealth, like a rank price or a plot upkeep

- Sinks aimed at big balances, like a wealth tax with an exemption
- Items that cannot be mass bought (limited stock, limited per player)

> **RULE OF THUMB**
> The richest 10% of players should hold under 50% of all money. Over 70% means new players are locked out and the market belongs to a few.

The endgame problem

Late-game players have everything. Without sinks, their money piles up and bids prices up in the player market. Give them things to spend on that are **unique or limited**:

- Cosmetics and titles
- Seasonal items that return in smaller numbers
- Large plots, island upgrades and special builds
- Server-wide projects they can fund together
- Prestige systems that reset a little progress for a permanent bonus

Seasons and resets

If your server runs in seasons, a reset is the ultimate sink: it brings every balance back to start. It is powerful, but it costs player trust. Rules for fair resets:

1. Announce the date weeks ahead.
2. Keep cosmetics, titles or a "hall of fame" so effort is remembered.
3. Fix the economy problems that caused the reset, or they return in a month.

More in Fixing inflation.

Planning notes

- A written price ladder for ranks, upgrades and plots
- A catch-up mechanic for new players
- At least three late-game sinks that are worth buying
- A plan for what the top player does with their money

Money in

Every way coins are created, and how to keep each one under control.

The faucet catalogue

Every common way money enters a server, how risky each one is and how to keep it in check.

A faucet is any rule that **creates coins**. Faucets are not bad. Players need income to enjoy the game. The trick is knowing every faucet you have and giving each one a limit.

Risk at a glance

FAUCET	INFLATION RISK	MAIN DANGER	BEST CONTROL
Selling items to the admin shop	High	Machines and farms that sell forever	Daily caps, falling prices
Jobs	High	Easy repeatable actions pay too much	Per-action cap, diminishing pay
Mob and block rewards	High	AFK farms and grinders	Anti-AFK, cap per hour
Quests and bounties	Medium	Repeatable quests become a farm	Daily limit, scale with progress
Daily and playtime rewards	Medium	Alt accounts	Playtime requirement, per-IP limit
Vote rewards	Low to medium	Many votes by many alts	Cooldown, modest reward
Crates	Medium	Cash payouts inside crates	Pay in items, not coins, mostly
Bank interest	High over time	Grows with wealth	Cap the balance that earns interest
Events and giveaways	Low	Staff generosity	Budget per event, log it
Starting balance	Low	Alt accounts	Keep it small
Admin commands	Variable	Staff giving money to friends	Log, audit, separate test accounts
Selling Pokémon or rare items (modpack)	Medium	Duped or mass-bred items	See Cobblemon

The common faucets in detail

Selling to the admin shop

This is almost always your **biggest faucet**. A player mines for an hour, sells everything and earns the hourly rate. That is fine. The danger is automation: a farm that runs while the player is asleep sells every hour of every day.

How to tame it:

- Set sell prices of farmable goods lower than hand-mined ones.
- Add daily sell limits per item.
- Reduce the price as the player sells more in a day.
- Do not buy items at all that can be mass produced by machines (for example cobblestone, sugar cane or bone meal).

Jobs

Jobs pay for repeated actions. Good for guiding players, risky when the action is trivial.

- Cap income per hour. If a player can earn 5x the intended rate by doing one trick, that trick is the real job.
- Pay less for actions that can be automated.
- Reduce pay after a certain number of actions per day.
- Pay for rare or skilled actions more than for easy ones.

Mob and block rewards

Plugins that pay money when you kill a mob or break a block are easy to abuse with a grinder or an auto-clicker. If you use them, set a per-hour cap and enable anti-AFK checks.

Quests, bounties and daily rewards

These are the **friendliest faucets** because they teach the game and give structure. Keep them small, make them repeat daily rather than hourly, and scale rewards by player progress so a veteran does not farm novice quests.

Voting

Vote rewards bring players, so most servers keep them. Make the reward modest and mostly items or keys. Vote-bots and alts are common, so do not let votes pay large coin amounts.

Crates

A crate that pays coins is a faucet. A crate that pays items is better because the item has to be sold, which goes through the shop's limits. Use coins as a small prize at most.

Bank interest

Interest scales with wealth, so the richest earn the most. Without care it becomes the biggest faucet on the server.

> **INTEREST COMPOUNDS**
> A 1% daily interest on every balance would multiply a player's money about 38 times in a year. Cap the balance that earns interest, use low rates and consider tiers that earn less above a limit.

Events and giveaways

Fun and effective, but they are a one-off faucet. Give each event a **budget**, note it in your weekly sheet and prefer items, cosmetics or titles over coins.

Build a faucet table

Keep a simple table like this for your own server and update it every month:

FAUCET	COINS PER PLAYER PER HOUR (MAX)	DAILY CAP	LAST REVIEWED
Shop sales	2,000	20,000	
Jobs	800	8,000	
Daily reward	500	500	



> **NUGGET SAYS**
> If you cannot fill in the "max per player per hour" column for a faucet, that faucet is out of control. Find the number, then decide whether you like it.

Next: taming faucets.

Taming faucets

Practical ways to cap, slow and shape income without making the game feel stingy.

You rarely need to remove a faucet. You usually need to **shape** it, so the first hour pays well and the thousandth hour does not explode.

The six levers

1. Caps

A cap says "this much per hour or per day". It is simple and it works.

- **Per action:** a job pays up to X per minute.
- **Per day:** a player can sell up to Y coins of an item at full price.
- **Per week:** limited rewards such as boss payouts.

> MAKE CAPS VISIBLE
> Players accept caps they can see. Show a message like "Daily sell limit reached, resets at midnight". A hidden cap feels like a bug.

2. Diminishing returns

Instead of a wall, use a slope. Each sale in a day pays a bit less than the one before. Players still feel progress, and a farm that runs for 20 hours earns much less than 20 times a single hour. Formulas are in Formulas.

3. Cooldowns

A cooldown spreads rewards over time. Daily rewards, bounties and bosses all benefit. Keep cooldowns long enough that checking in does not become a chore.

4. Requirements

Gate large rewards behind playtime, rank or progress. A reward for "first 5 hours online" stops brand-new alt accounts from collecting it.

5. Scaling with progress

A quest that pays 500 coins is generous on day one and silly at hour 500. Scale rewards to a player's stage, or switch them to non-coin rewards later in the game.

6. Pay in items, not coins

An item is only worth something once it has been used or sold. That gives you a second chance to control it, through shop limits and sinks. A reward of "a stack of food and a repair token" is far safer than 5,000 coins.

Anti-AFK and automation

AFK and auto-clicker income is the most common reason faucets run away.

- Use an AFK detector. Stop paying rewards while a player is idle.
- Pay less for repeated identical actions.
- Limit rewards for killing mobs from a grinder (many plugins have a "spawner mob" setting).
- Block or limit auto-clickers with an anti-cheat.
- Treat unusual income as a signal. Check any account earning more than 3 to 5 times the server's average.

> **ALT ACCOUNTS**
> Anyone can create extra accounts for daily rewards, votes and starting balances. Link rewards to playtime, use per-IP limits where fair and review the richest new accounts weekly.

A simple budget method

1. Decide what an average active player should earn in an hour (the hourly rate).
2. Decide the **mix**: for example 50% from selling, 25% from jobs, 15% from quests and 10% from other sources.
3. Set caps so that a player who maxes every faucet earns at most about **1.5x** the hourly rate.
4. Check the real numbers each week. If one faucet is above its share, tighten it.

Quick fixes when a faucet is too strong

SYMPTOM	FIRST FIX
One item sells for far too much	Lower the sell price, add a daily cap
One job dominates	Cut its pay, add diminishing returns
Overnight income spikes	Anti-AFK, check for farms and auto-clickers
A new event doubled money	Cap the event reward, or end it early with a note
New accounts earn a lot	Raise playtime requirements for rewards

Next: pair every faucet with a sink. See the sink catalogue.

Money out

Every way coins disappear, plus taxes and fees that actually work.

The sink catalogue

Every common way to remove money from a server, with the sinks players actually enjoy at the top.

A sink **destroys coins**. The best sinks are the ones players choose gladly because they get something they want. The worst are hidden fees that feel like theft.

The best sinks, ranked

SINK	FUN FACTOR	DRAIN POWER	NOTES
Cosmetics, titles, pets	High	Medium	Prestige spending. Great for late game
Land: plots, claims, island upgrades	High	High	Scales with progress
Rank-ups and unlocks	High	High	Clear goals, one-off
Repairs, enchant and anvil costs	Medium	Medium	Constant, everyone uses it
Shop buy prices and spreads	Medium	High	The quiet workhorse
Rent and upkeep	Medium	High	Recurring sink that matches ownership
Auction and trade fees	Low	Medium	Scales with market activity
Teleport, command and kit costs	Medium	Low to medium	Convenience sink
Casino and games	Medium	High	Must be fair and capped. Lose limits help
Limited-stock items	High	Medium	Creates real demand
Seasonal or event shops	High	Medium	Time-limited, easy to sell
Wealth or idle tax	Low	High	Targets hoarding, keep rules simple
Death cost	Low	Low	Can feel harsh. Use carefully

Good sinks versus bad sinks

A **good sink** has a reason, a reward and clear rules:

- Players see the price before paying.
- They get something they value.
- Rich players pay more than new players.

A **bad sink** punishes players for playing:

- Hidden fees.
- Tax on every small action.

- Costs that hit new players harder than rich ones.
- "Pay or lose your stuff" rules.

> **THE FUN TEST**
> Would a player tell a friend about this purchase? Cosmetics, plots and ranks pass. A 10% tax on moving items does not.

Sink ideas by type

Prestige sinks (rich players)

- Cosmetic particle trails, hats, tags, titles
- Pets and mounts
- Large builds or exclusive plots
- Name or color rights, banners and statues
- Leaderboard fame (donating to a community project)

Progress sinks (everyone)

- Rank-up costs
- Skill or job levels that cost coins to unlock
- Island or plot expansions
- Storage and home slot upgrades
- Kit upgrades

Convenience sinks (everyone)

- Warp and teleport fees
- Repair and rename costs
- Shop fees
- Mail or storage fees (small)

Recurring sinks

- Plot rent
- Shop rent for player shops
- Upkeep for claims or islands

Recurring sinks are powerful because they match ownership. Someone with a huge base pays more over time than someone with a cabin.

Time-limited sinks

- Seasonal shops with items that rotate
- Events with entry fees and prizes (careful: prizes are faucets)
- Auctions of rare items run by the server, with the winning bid destroyed

Gambling

A well-run casino destroys coins because of the **house edge**. Keep it small, cap bets and set daily loss limits. Be careful: it can hurt vulnerable players and attract exploits. See Stopping exploits.

How much sink do you need?

If your faucets create 100,000 coins per day, your sinks should destroy 80,000 to 100,000. If you are not sure, measure:

1. Add up what each sink removed last week, using your logs.
2. Compare it to what faucets created.
3. If you fall short, raise a sink or add a new one. See Fixing inflation.



NUGGET SAYS

Start with the sinks players want to buy anyway. Fees and taxes are the seasoning, not the meal.

Next: taxes and fees.

Taxes and fees

Which taxes work on a Minecraft server, sensible rates and the rules that keep them fair.

Taxes are the sink most owners reach for first. Used well they are quiet and steady. Used badly they annoy everyone and push players to trade outside the system.

Where does the tax money go?

You have two options, and you should pick one on purpose:

- **Burn it.** The coins are destroyed. This is a real sink.
- **Treasury.** The server keeps it and pays it back as prizes, events or public builds. Fun, but it is **not** a sink. Count it as money you will create again.

A good mix is to burn most of it and recycle a small share into community projects.

The taxes that work

TAX OR FEE	SUGGESTED RATE	WHO PAYS	NOTES
Player transfer tax (`/pay`)	2% to 5%	The sender	Skip tiny amounts so it does not feel petty
Auction listing fee	1% to 3%	Seller, at listing	Stops spam listings. Not refunded
Auction sale fee	3% to 8%	Seller, at sale	The core marketplace sink
Player shop sales tax	2% to 5%	Seller	Should match auction rules so it is fair
Admin shop spread	60% to 80% gap	Everyone	Built in, no extra tax needed
Wealth tax	0.5% to 2% per week	Balances above a threshold	Exempt new players. Keep the rule simple
Plot or shop rent	Match its value	Owner	Recurring sink
Bank withdrawal fee	0% to 2%	Depositor	Optional
Luxury cosmetics fee	Built into price	Buyer	Always better than a separate tax
Death tax	0% to 5% of balance	Player	Use carefully. Many players hate it

HOW BIG CAN A TAX SINK BE?

Your players trade 2 million coins per day through `/pay` and the auction house. A 4% average tax destroys 80,000 coins a day. That alone covers most of a 100,000 coin faucet.

Rules for good taxes

1. **Visible.** Tell players the rate before they confirm. A message such as "Fee: 4% (40 coins)" is enough.
2. **Simple.** Fewer than three tax types. If players need a calculator, it is too complex.
3. **Proportional.** A percentage works better than a flat fee, because a flat fee punishes small trades and barely touches big ones.
4. **Predictable.** Do not change rates every week. Change slowly and announce it.
5. **Exempt the basics.** New players and very small transactions should pay nothing.
6. **Hard to dodge.** A tax on `/pay` can be avoided by trading items. Add a tax or fee on the shop or auction paths too, and watch for suspicious trades.

Avoiding tax dodging

Watch for these common ways to skip tax:

- Trading valuables for cheap items (player A "sells" a diamond block for 1 coin and a deal on the side)
- Using chest shops to move money without the main marketplace
- Splitting a large payment into many small ones to stay under a threshold
- Alt accounts moving money between themselves

Ways to respond:

- Put the same fee on every trade path.
- Log large or repeated transfers and review them.
- Treat obvious abuse as an exploit and enforce rules fairly. See Stopping exploits.

Wealth tax: handle with care

A wealth tax works against hoarding but is the most disliked tax. If you use one:

- Exempt a base amount (for example the first 1 million coins) so only the rich are affected.
- Use a small weekly rate, not a large one-off.
- Offer a way to avoid it by spending, such as a luxury shop or a donation project with perks.
- Explain **why** in public: "We want money to be spent, not buried."

> **DO NOT TAX WHAT THE PLAYER CANNOT CONTROL**
> Taxes on kills, drops or normal movement feel like punishment. Tax **choices**: trades, spending and ownership.

Starting rates for a new server

ITEM	STARTING RATE
`/pay` tax	3% (free under 100 coins)
Auction listing fee	1%
Auction sale fee	5%
Player shop tax	3%
Admin shop sell price	30% of buy price
Wealth tax	None until you need it

Run for two weeks, read the numbers from Tracking the economy and adjust by small steps.

Inflation

Spot it early, fix it calmly, and measure it every week.

Spotting inflation

The early warning signs, the numbers that prove it and the usual causes.

Inflation sneaks up. It starts with a few high prices in the auction house and ends with players who cannot afford a stack of food. The earlier you see it, the cheaper the fix.

Signs players will tell you

- "Everything is so expensive now."
- The same item costs more in the auction house each week.
- New players say they cannot catch up.
- Rich players say there is nothing to buy.
- Shop prices feel silly: nobody bothers to sell to the admin shop.

Signs you can measure

SIGNAL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR	HEALTHY	WORRYING
Money per active player	Week over week	Within about 5%	Up more than 10% to 15%
Sinks vs faucets	Sinks divided by faucets	80% to 100%	Under 60%
Price index	Median price of a basket of common items	Flat or slightly rising	Rising steadily
Top 10% wealth share	Share of all money held by the top 10%	Under 50%	Over 70%
Average balance in days of income	Balance divided by daily income	7 to 60 days	Over 90 days
New player progress	Hours to first rank	Steady	Growing

Use the health check to calculate most of these in a minute.

The price index

Choose 8 to 12 items that players buy or sell often: for example iron ingot, wheat, logs, diamonds, food and an enchanted item. Each week, record the **median** auction price of each (the middle price, which ignores crazy outliers). Add them up. Compare to last week.

If the index rises 3% a week for a month, inflation is quietly at work.

The usual causes

1. A faucet got too strong

A new job, event or reward pays more than expected. Check recent changes first.

2. Automation arrived

Players built farms that sell all day. Check sales per hour and see if a few players are far above the rest.

3. An exploit

A bug lets someone make money out of nothing. Look for a few accounts with sudden huge balances. See Stopping exploits.

4. Not enough sinks

The server grew, but your sinks did not scale. Players have more than they can spend.

5. Hoarding

Money piles up because nothing worth buying exists at the top end.

6. Interest and passive income

Bank interest, rent income and any other "money while away" system grows with wealth.

7. Too many players got rich at once

A big event or giveaway pushed a lot of money in at the same time.

A quick diagnosis

1. Compare **faucets and sinks** by type for the last two weeks. Which grew?
2. Look at the **top 10 earners**. Is one method behind most of the income?
3. Check **recent changes**: plugin updates, new events, new shop items, changed prices.
4. Check **suspicious accounts**: brand new, very high income, AFK.
5. Check the **price index**. Which items rose first?



NUGGET IS WORRIED

If you see money per player jumping more than 15% in one week, treat it as an incident. Pause what changed, look for an exploit and check the logs before anything else.

Next: Fixing inflation.

Fixing inflation

A calm playbook, from gentle nudges to emergency measures, plus how to handle deflation and resets.

Use the **gentlest lever that works**. Players forgive a small nudge. They do not forgive a surprise.

The ladder of responses

STEP	WHAT YOU DO	WHEN TO USE IT	PLAYER IMPACT
1	Add or improve a sink players want	Mild inflation, caught early	None, feels like a new feature
2	Tighten a faucet slightly (caps, sell price)	One faucet clearly leads	Small
3	Raise taxes and fees by a point or two	You need steady drain	Small to medium
4	Add a temporary event sink (limited shop, auction)	You need a one-off drain	Fun
5	Remove or rework a broken faucet	Faucet is clearly broken	Medium
6	Wealth tax or upkeep above a threshold	Hoarding is the problem	Medium to high
7	Price reset: change shop and item prices	Prices drifted a lot	High
8	Currency reform: convert balances (for example divide by 10)	Numbers are absurd	High
9	Economy reset or season wipe	Trust in the money is gone	Very high

Move up the ladder one step at a time and measure for a week after each change.

Step by step: your first response

1. **Stop the bleeding.** If an exploit or a bug is adding money, pause the shop, the job or the faucet while you fix it.
2. **Find the cause.** Use Spotting inflation.
3. **Fix the cause, not the symptom.** If a farm sells too much, cap the farm, not every sale.
4. **Add a sink or two** that players like. A sale on cosmetics or a limited-time shop works well.
5. **Announce what you changed.** Short, honest and without blame. See the template below.
6. **Measure again** in 7 days with the health check.

Handling an exploit

1. Pause the exploited feature immediately.
2. Check logs for who used it and how much they earned.
3. Remove illegally gained money. Take it back as a balance adjustment, not a ban, unless there is clear abuse.
4. Decide a fair policy: first offense warning and rollback, repeated abuse is a ban.
5. Close the hole, then reopen the feature.
6. Tell players what happened in a short post. See Stopping exploits.

Fixing deflation

Players broke and quitting is as bad as inflation.

- Raise rewards, or reduce the price of core items.
- Add small, friendly faucets: daily rewards, easy quests, a weekend bonus.
- Remove or soften the harshest fees.
- Check that early game still has quick wins.

Price resets and currency reform

If prices have drifted too far, you can:

- **Reprice shops.** Players adapt in a week or two.
- **Reform the currency.** For example, divide every balance and every price by 10. Everyone keeps their relative wealth and the numbers become readable again.
- **Reset the economy.** A fresh start. Last resort.

> RESETS COST TRUST
> A reset can fix the numbers, but it cannot fix the habit that created the problem. Fix the **system** first or the same thing happens again.

Sample announcement

> **Economy update.** Over the last two weeks, prices rose faster than we want. We found the cause: sell prices for farm items were too high. From Monday, farm items sell for less and there is a daily sell limit. To balance it, we are adding a limited-time cosmetics shop. We will review the numbers again in a week and share the result.

Short, clear and no blame.

After the fix

- Record the numbers before and after
- Write what you changed, the date and the reason in a log
- Re-run the health check next week
- Add a note about the root cause so future staff learn from it

Tracking the economy

Which numbers to write down every week, how to log money safely and how to build a one-page economy sheet.

You cannot balance what you do not measure. The good news: a handful of numbers, written down once a week, tells you nearly everything.

The weekly sheet

Create a spreadsheet with one row per week and these columns:

COLUMN	HOW TO GET IT
Date	The same day each week
Active players	Players who logged in that week
Total money	Sum of all balances (many economy plugins can show this, or use a command or database query)
Money per active player	Total money divided by active players
Faucets per day	Average coins created per day, from logs or plugin stats
Sinks per day	Average coins destroyed per day
Sinks vs faucets (%)	Sinks divided by faucets
Top 10% share	Share of money held by the richest 10% of players
Price index	Sum of median prices of your basket
Notable events	Anything you changed or ran this week

Add a chart of **money per player** and **sinks vs faucets** over time. These two lines tell most of the story.

What to log

Turn on logging for anything that moves money:

- Every admin money command (who, who to, how much)
- Every transfer above a size threshold (for example 10,000 coins)
- Shop sales and purchases by item
- Job, quest and reward payouts by source
- Tax and fee totals
- Plugin errors involving money

Keep logs long enough to look back at least a month. Review the biggest transactions each week.

Alerts worth setting up

- A balance jump of more than 10 times a player's usual weekly income
- A new account that earns far above average
- Many transfers between the same two accounts
- A sudden jump in total money
- A big sell order of a normally rare item

> **MAKE IT EASY FOR STAFF**
> Put the weekly sheet in a shared document and link it in your staff channel. A short "economy report" post each week builds the habit.

How to count faucets and sinks

If your plugins do not report them directly, estimate:

1. **Faucets**: add up all payouts from jobs, shop sales, quests, rewards, crates, votes and interest. Use logs, or a plugin that reports by source.
2. **Sinks**: add up all purchases from admin shops, taxes, fees, rent, rank-ups, cosmetics and repair costs.
3. **Check:** the change in total money should be about faucets minus sinks. If the numbers do not match, you are missing a source. Find it. That missing source is often the real problem.

> **THE SANITY CHECK**
> Total money change = faucets - sinks. If your measured numbers do not add up, something is hidden. Hunt it down.

Reading your charts

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT LIKELY MEANS
Money per player rising steadily	Faucets ahead of sinks. Add a sink or tighten a faucet
Money per player jumps then flat	An event or exploit. Check that week's notes
Money per player falling	Sinks ahead of faucets, or a reset worked
Price index rising, money flat	Items getting scarce, or demand shifted. Check supply
Top 10% share climbing	Wealth is concentrating. Add catch-up and rich-player sinks

Run the health check weekly

The health check uses these same numbers and gives you a verdict in one click. Combine it with the weekly checklist.

Your first month

WEEK	GOAL
1	Set up the sheet and logging. Do not change anything
2	Record the numbers. Find your biggest faucet and biggest sink
3	Make one small change and note it
4	Compare to week 2 and decide what to do next

Markets

Admin shops, the auction house and player shops.

The admin shop

How to design a server-run shop that gives players a safe place to trade without becoming a money printer.

The admin shop (also called server shop or system shop) is where players buy from and sell to the server. It is the backbone of most economies, so small mistakes here are big.

What the admin shop is for

1. **Give new players a place to start.** They need something to sell and something to buy.
2. **Set a price floor and ceiling.** Player markets stay near the admin price.
3. **Drain money** through the buy/sell gap.
4. **Let you steer behavior.** Cheap items encourage use. Expensive ones encourage trading.

Design rules

Sell low, buy high

- Players should sell to the shop for **20% to 40%** of the buy price.
- If a player can sell at 100 and buy at 100, it is a free storage system, and any small price mismatch becomes an exploit.

Limit what the shop buys

Do not buy everything. Buy a **short list** of items that new players can get by hand. Leave out:

- Items made by auto-farms (cobblestone, sugar cane, kelp, bone meal, gunpowder, iron if you have iron farms)
- Rare or valuable items you want players to trade with each other
- Items that can be crafted into higher-priced ones

Limit what the shop sells

- Basic building blocks, food, tools and consumables are fine.
- Rare items (elytra, tridents, nether stars) should not be in the shop, or should cost a lot.
- Limit stock for sensitive items.

Use limits and slopes

Every item the shop buys needs a daily limit or a falling price. See Pricing items.

Keep categories small and clear

A shop with 400 items is hard to balance. Aim for under 150 and group them clearly. Fewer items are easier to audit.

Shop pitfalls

PITFALL	WHY IT HURTS	FIX
Same buy and sell price	Free storage and arbitrage	Use a spread
Selling ingredients above the result price	Loop: craft, sell, repeat	Run the loop test
Buying farm output	Machines become faucets	Remove from the sell list
Prices not updated	Items drift out of balance	Review monthly
Items everywhere	Overwhelming and hard to maintain	Trim to the essentials
No stock limit on rare items	Rich players empty the shop	Per-player and global limits

Dynamic shop or fixed shop?

TYPE	GOOD	BAD
Fixed prices	Predictable, easy to audit	Never reacts to supply
Dynamic prices	Reacts to what players do	Can swing wildly, needs a floor and ceiling
Hybrid	Fixed base with a small dynamic factor	More setup

For most servers, fixed prices with sell limits are enough. Add dynamic pricing later if you like the extra life.

Rotating and special shops

- **Daily or weekly rotation:** a few featured items at a discount creates interest.
- **Limited-stock shop:** rare cosmetics or items that sell out.
- **Event shops:** exchange event tokens for rewards.

Keep their prices above what the item is worth in the player market, so they act as sinks and not as faucets.

Shop audit

Run this once per month:

1. Export all prices to a spreadsheet.
2. For every item, check sell price is below buy price.
3. For every recipe, check output sell price is below the sum of the ingredients' sell prices.
4. Sort by daily sales volume. Review the top 10 items and see if they should still be there.
5. Check for items that never sell. Remove or reprice them.

Player markets

Auction houses, player shops and trading. How to make them lively, fair and drain a little money.

A player market is where the real economy happens. When it works, prices come from what players want. You mostly watch and protect it.

The tools

TOOL	HOW IT WORKS	GOOD FOR
Auction house	Players list items for sale, others buy or bid	Easy trading, searching, no need to be online
Player shops (chest shops or shop GUIs)	Players set up shops in the world	Community feel, shopping districts
Direct trade	Players trade face to face	Rare deals, but easy to scam
Bounty or request board	Players post what they want to buy	Niche items

Offer at least one of the first two. The auction house is easiest to track and tax.

Keep the market healthy

Listing fees and sale fees

A small fee when listing and a larger one when sold keeps the market clean.

- **Listing fee** (1% to 3%) stops spam and test listings.
- **Sale fee** (3% to 8%) is your main marketplace sink.

Limit listings

A cap per player (for example 10 to 20 active listings) prevents one person flooding the market and keeps the database light.

Price floors on admin-backed items

If a player lists wheat for 1 coin and the admin shop buys it for 2, players will buy the cheap wheat and flip it. Either block listings below the admin sell price or accept that the admin price is the floor.

Expiry

Listings should expire after a few days. Dead listings clutter the market and hide real prices.

Search and sort

A market that is hard to browse is a market that does not work. Good search and "sort by price" matter more than you think.

Player shops and land

If players can create shops, make shop space an asset:

- Shop plots cost money or rent.
- Rent grows with location (spawn is more valuable).
- Limit the number of shops per player.

That turns a place to trade into a sink and a reason to compete for prime spots.

Preventing monopolies

A monopoly happens when one player controls most of an item. Watch for:

- One player buying out every item of a type and relisting higher
- Cartels agreeing not to undercut each other

Possible tools:

- Per-player buy limits on rare items
- Admin shop as a ceiling for common items
- Higher fees for very large purchases
- Clear rules against collusion, enforced fairly

Scams and safety

- Make trades confirm clearly with both sides seeing the same item.
- Use a GUI, not chat commands, for trades.
- Log trades. A log makes disputes quick.
- Have a clear refund policy: usually none for honest mistakes, yes for bugs.

> **SEED THE MARKET**
> A new market looks empty. Staff or a few friendly players can list useful items at fair prices so new players learn how it works. Keep that stock small, honest and logged.

What to watch in the numbers

METRIC	HEALTHY	WORRYING
Number of listings	Steady or growing	Falling to nothing
Items sold / items listed	50% or more	Under 20% (prices too high)
Price vs admin buy price	Above the admin sell price, below the admin buy price	Outside that range
Fees collected	Stable share of trade volume	Falling (trading outside the market)

Fair play

Welcome new players, stop exploits and change things without anger.

Fairness

How to welcome new players, avoid pay-to-win, share information openly and change the rules without anger.

A fair economy is one where **effort is rewarded, rules are clear and nobody wins by cheating or by money alone**. Players forgive almost everything except feeling cheated.

The fairness checklist

- New players can reach the first goals within their first session.
- Veterans cannot buy their way past everything on day one of a season.
- Rules for money are public: rates, caps, fees.
- Staff follow the same rules as players.
- Exploits are handled the same way for everyone.
- Changes are announced before they happen.

Welcoming new players

Money is the least of a newcomer's worries, but a bad first week ends many servers.

- **Starter kit** with tools and food, small enough that it does not feed alts.
- **A short quest chain** that teaches the economy: sell something, buy something, find the market.
- **Cheap first goals**: the first rank or first plot should take an hour or two.
- **A protected price range**: items a newcomer needs (food, torches, basic tools) stay cheap through the admin shop.
- **Friendly rewards for helping**: a veteran who guides a newbie earns a small cosmetic, not coins.

> HELP, DO NOT FEED
> A big gift of money makes the first week easy and the second week confusing. Give things to do and things to buy, not piles of coins.

Avoiding pay-to-win

Players tolerate cosmetics and convenience for sale. They hate buying power.

FINE	NOT FINE
Cosmetic ranks, tags, particles	Selling in-game coins or items for real money
Convenience (extra homes, more storage) with modest limits	Real-money stat boosts or exclusive powerful gear
Supporter perks that save time, not money	Faster money income for payers

If you do sell perks, keep a clear line between "looks" and "power", and check Mojang's current rules.

Gaps between rich and poor

Some difference is natural and fun. Too much kills the game.

- Track the **top 10% share** and keep it below 50% to 60%.
- Use sinks that scale with wealth: rent, upkeep, luxury goods.
- Create ways for newer players to earn well from niche jobs (farming, rare drops, services), not only from long grinding.
- Put some of the best rewards behind **skill or effort**, not money.

Be open about the rules

- Publish tax rates, daily limits and rank prices on your wiki or rules page.
- Explain **why** a rule exists, in one sentence.
- Share a short economy report each month. Players love seeing the numbers.

Changing things fairly

1. Give notice: at least a few days for small changes, a week or more for big ones.
2. Explain the reason in plain words.
3. Protect past effort where you can: grandfather items players already bought, or refund a price drop.
4. Do not retroactively punish players for using a system you built.

Template: a rule change post

> **What is changing:** Sell prices for X drop by 30%. **When:** Monday, 18:00 server time. **Why:** Farms were creating too much money and prices were rising. **How we are making up for it:** New daily quests, and a limited-time shop. **Questions:** Ask in the staff channel or reply here.

Staff and money

- Staff do not give themselves or friends money or items. If you need to test something, use a clearly marked test account and log it.
- Admin money commands are limited to a few trusted people and always logged.

- Staff may not profit from knowing about a price change before it is announced.
- Giveaways follow a written budget.

Handling complaints

When a player says "it is not fair", ask three questions:

1. **Is it a bug or a rule?** If a bug, fix and compensate fairly.
2. **Who is affected?** Everyone, or a few? A rule that hurts many is a design issue.
3. **Can we explain it simply?** If you cannot, the rule may be too complex.

Stopping exploits

The loops, dupes and tricks players use to break an economy, how to test for them and how to respond.

Every economy gets exploited. The aim is to find the holes before your players do and to respond quickly and fairly when they do.

The common exploits

EXPLOIT	HOW IT WORKS	HOW TO STOP IT
Crafting loop	Buy ingredients, craft, sell the result for more	Test every recipe. Sell price of result must not exceed ingredients
Buy/sell arbitrage	Buy from one shop, sell to another for more	One price source. Buy price above sell price everywhere
Farm automation	Machines sell items all day	Daily caps, do not buy farm output
Alt accounts	Many accounts collect rewards or starting money	Playtime requirements, per-IP limits, review new accounts
Wash trading	Two accounts trade back and forth to dodge tax or fake volume	Same fee on every path, log repeated pairs
Item or money dupes	A bug creates items or coins from nothing	Keep software updated, audit item counts, log big jumps
Race conditions	Doing two actions at once to spend or sell the same thing twice	Use well-tested plugins, watch for odd balance changes
Rounding tricks	Tiny trades round tax to zero	Test 1 coin trades and fractional rates
Negative or huge numbers	Command input that flips signs or overflows	Reject negative and absurdly large inputs
AFK farming	Autoclickers or AFK pools earn income	Anti-AFK and an anti-cheat
Price manipulation	Buying all stock to raise prices or crash them	Limits per player, price bands
Admin abuse	Staff give themselves or friends money	Logging, few admins, audits

The loop test (do this before launch)

For each recipe where both the inputs and the output can be bought or sold:

1. Compute the cheapest way to **buy** all the inputs.
2. Compute the best way to **sell** the output.

3. If selling the output pays more than buying the inputs, you have a loop.

Do the same for chains. Raw material to processed to block to raw material is a typical loop (for example ingots to blocks and back, when one direction is priced differently).

> **A LOOP**
> Buy 9 iron ingots at 10 each (90). Craft one iron block. Sell the block for 100. Profit: 10 coins per cycle, with no limit. Fix: the block sells for less than 9 x the ingot sell price.

Testing like a player

Spend an hour trying to break your own economy:

- Sell and buy the same item back to back.
- Pay a tiny amount and a huge amount.
- Run commands with 0, -1 and 999999999 as the amount.
- Spam a command from two windows at the same time.
- Use a fresh account to see what a new player can claim.
- Trade with an alt and look at the logs.

Detection

Keep a weekly **suspicious list**:

- Top 10 balance increases for the week
- New accounts with big balances
- Accounts with income far above the average
- Repeated transfers between the same two accounts
- Items selling in unusual numbers

You will find honest champions, but you will also find exploits.

Responding to an exploit

1. **Stop it.** Pause the shop, job or feature. A few hours of downtime beats a week of cleanup.
2. **Contain it.** Freeze the involved accounts' ability to move money.
3. **Measure it.** How much money was created? Who got it?
4. **Remove it.** Take back the illegal gain. If the money was spent, deduct it from future earnings or take items of equal value.
5. **Decide fairly.** A common policy:
    - First offense: warning and the money removed
    - Knowing, repeated or large abuse: temporary or permanent ban
    - Reporting an exploit honestly: reward them

6. **Fix it.** Close the hole, then reopen.
7. **Tell players** in a short, calm post.

> **REWARD HONEST REPORTS**
> Make it easy and rewarding to report a bug: a private channel and a small prize. Players who report exploits are worth more to you than players who hide them.

Policy you should write down

- What counts as an exploit?
- What happens on the first, second and third time?
- Who decides, and how can a player appeal?
- Is money from an exploit always removed? (Usually yes.)

A written policy makes you consistent, and consistency is fairness.

Your modes

Advice for Oneblock, Survival and the Cobblemon modpack.

Oneblock

Economy advice for a server where everyone mines the same single block. Resources are endless, so the clicks are the real currency.

In Oneblock, each player stands on a tiny island and breaks one block that keeps coming back with new blocks, mobs and chests. That creates a very different economy from normal survival.

What makes Oneblock special

- **Resources are infinite, but limited by clicks.** The real limit is how fast a player can break blocks.
- **Players start with almost nothing**, so early game money is slow and every coin matters.
- **Everything is concentrated.** Players do the same thing for hours, so one overpriced drop can dominate.
- **Space is tiny.** There is no land to buy in the usual sense, so sinks must come from upgrades.
- **Auto-clickers and AFK** are the biggest threat, because breaking the same block is easy to automate.

Price by clicks, not by rarity

Time yourself. In a test island, how many blocks does a normal player break in an hour at each phase? That is your **blocks per hour** number. Use it to set the base value.

> **A CLICKS-BASED PRICE**
> If a player breaks about 2,000 blocks an hour and an hour should earn 1,500 coins, then an average block is worth about 0.75 coins. A rare drop that appears once every 100 blocks should be worth a lot more than 75 coins, because it is rarer and more useful.

Sell prices

- **Common drops** (dirt, stone, sand, cobblestone): sell for almost nothing or not at all. They arrive by the thousand.
- **Mid-value drops** (logs, ores, crops): moderate prices with daily caps.
- **Rare drops** (special blocks and chest loot): higher prices, and a cap per day.
- **Mob drops**: cap them, because mobs appear in bursts.

Faucets to watch

FAUCET	RISK	CONTROL
Selling block drops	Very high	Daily caps, falling prices
Mob rewards	High	Cap per hour, anti-AFK
Phase or milestone rewards	Medium	One-time, scale with phase
Daily quests	Medium	Cap and scale
Island level rewards	Medium	One-time per level

Sinks that work in Oneblock

- **Island expansion** (bigger platform, extra layers, more space for farms)
- **Phase or level unlocks** that cost coins as well as clicks
- **Team slots and island members**
- **Island upgrades**: faster regeneration, extra loot chance, a storage chest
- **Cosmetics** for the island, the block and the player
- **Generators and upgrades** that cost money to build and run
- **Visitor perks and warps**
- **Prestige upgrades** at high phases

Since players spend most of their time on one island, upgrades there are a natural sink.

Auto-clickers and AFK

Because the action is just clicking, an auto-clicker can pay for hours while a player sleeps.

- Use an anti-cheat that detects auto-clickers.
- Pay less for sustained clicking without movement or breaks.
- Use an AFK system that stops rewards when idle.
- Keep a cap per hour so that even a perfect click bot earns a bounded amount.

Island-level economies

Many Oneblock servers use an island level system. Treat it as part of the economy:

- Each block placed adds points. Make high-value blocks worth more points, but cost coins to obtain.
- Rewards for reaching a level should be items or one-time money, not repeating payouts.
- Leaderboards drive spending on prestige blocks. That is a sink.

Starting out

New players have nothing. Make the first hour smooth:

- A small starter kit
- A quick first phase with fast rewards
- A first goal that takes under an hour (the first expansion or a basic rank)
- A shop that buys what the first phase gives, at a low but fair price

Checklist for Oneblock

- Measure blocks per hour at each phase
- Set sell prices from that rate
- Cap or remove sales of very common blocks
- Cap rewards for kills and clicks
- Create at least three upgrade sinks players want
- Enable anti-AFK and an auto-clicker check
- Review sales volume weekly

Survival

Economy advice for a normal survival world with big maps, farms, villagers and land.

Survival has a real world, real land and real machines. Money here has to compete with a game where you can make nearly everything yourself. That means your economy works best when it **adds convenience and goals**, not when it tries to replace the game.

What makes Survival special

- **Players can farm anything.** The shop competes with the world.
- **Automation is a core part of the game.** Iron farms, crop farms and mob grinders run all day.
- **Land is a real asset.** Claims, plots and a good base location matter.
- **Villager trading** is its own economy, and players can get ahead using it.
- **Players trade items more than coins.** Many deals are item for item.

Rule one: do not pay for what machines make

Machines make cobblestone, sugar cane, kelp, bone meal, gunpowder, iron and more. If the shop buys those, a farm turns into an endless faucet. Either:

- Do not buy them at all, or
- Buy them at a very low price with a tight daily cap.

Pay for things that need **effort and skill**: rare ores, rare drops, exploration finds, special crops and crafted goods.

Faucets

FAUCET	RISK	NOTES
Shop sales	High	Keep the list short and capped
Jobs	Medium to high	Pay for valuable actions, not trivial ones
Mob rewards	High	Mob grinders. Cap per hour, ignore spawner mobs
Quests and bounties	Medium	Fun but limit repeats
Daily and vote rewards	Medium	Small and gated by playtime
Player shops	None (transfer)	Money moves between players, not created
Villager trading	Indirect	Emeralds can be a hidden currency. See below

Sinks

- **Land claims and plots:** a one-time price plus ongoing upkeep.
- **Shop rent** for player shop areas.
- **Enchanting and repair costs** (admin enchant shops).
- **Rank-ups and kits.**
- **Cosmetics and titles.**
- **Teleports and warps.**
- **Seasonal items.**
- **Server projects:** community builds that need donations.

Villagers and emeralds

Villager trading can create items and emeralds that skip your economy completely. Options:

- Accept it. Emeralds become a second currency and players trade them in the market.
- Limit villager farms and trading halls with a plugin or server rules.
- Allow emeralds in the shop at a fair price so that they connect to your coin.

The important point is to **decide**, not to be surprised.

Land is your best sink

Land is limited and everyone needs it. Make it cost something and keep costing something:

- Initial claim cost scaled by size
- Weekly or monthly upkeep
- Bigger claims cost more per block
- Prime areas (near spawn) cost more
- Abandoned claims expire

That makes inactive players leave room and gives rich players something real to spend on.

Admin shop for Survival

- Keep sell list small.
- Buy things like rare ores, special crops and exploration items at modest prices.
- Sell basic items cheaply so new players can get going.
- Do not sell what you want players to trade with each other.

Player economy

Survival thrives when players trade. Help it:

- A good auction house.
- Shop districts with rent.
- A currency players trust.
- Spawn market events and shop contests.

Seasonal wipes

Many survival servers wipe on a schedule. A fresh map is a fresh economy. If you wipe:

- Reset balances too, or the old rich dominate the new world.
- Keep cosmetics, titles and a hall of fame.
- Reuse what worked, fix what did not.

Checklist for Survival

- Shop buys only hand-gathered or skill items
- Machine output sells at the minimum or not at all
- Land has an upkeep sink
- Villager trading has a plan
- Cap job and mob income
- Late-game sinks: cosmetics, large claims, projects
- Weekly review of the top earners

Cobblemon modpack

Economy advice for a server where players catch, battle and trade creatures. Includes what changes when the server runs on mods instead of plugins.

A Cobblemon server is built around catching and battling creatures, not only mining. The economy has to value things like captures, battles and rare finds.

> **CHECK YOUR OWN PACK**
> Modpack servers are usually built on Fabric or NeoForge instead of Paper. That means normal plugin advice does not always apply and the available economy tools depend on your pack. Names and features change with versions, so verify what your pack includes before relying on any of this.

What makes it different

- **Value lives in creatures.** Rare, shiny or well-trained creatures are worth far more than any block.
- **Players spend on gear**: capture balls, healing items, held items, evolution items, training items.
- **Income comes from battles and catches** as much as from mining and farming.
- **Trading creatures is the main player market.** It is harder to price than items.
- **Duping and trade abuse** can wreck value quickly.

Faucets

FAUCET	RISK	CONTROL
NPC trainer or battle rewards	High if repeatable	Cooldowns, daily caps
Selling caught creatures or items to the server	High	Low prices, caps, no buying of mass-caught common creatures
Tournaments and events	Medium	Budget each event
Quests and daily tasks	Medium	Daily limits, scale with progress
Gym or boss-style rewards	Medium	One-time or weekly
Standard shop sales (mining, farming)	Medium	Same rules as other modes

Be careful with repeatable battles. If a player can beat the same trainer 200 times for money, that fight is a job with no cap.

Sinks

- **Capture balls**, especially better ones. They are a constant sink because players use them.

- **Healing and revival items.**
- **Evolution and training items.**
- **Held items and boosters.**
- **Cosmetics**: outfits, trails, trainer titles.
- **Shop items for base building.**
- **Fees on creature trading** (a small percentage to the server).
- **Entry fees for events** and special areas.
- **Breeding or hatching costs**, if available in your pack.
- **Limited-time shops** for rare items.

Pricing creatures

If you let players sell creatures to each other, you need some guardrails:

- Let the **market** set prices, but consider a minimum fee.
- Tax trades by a percentage (3% to 8%) to create a sink.
- Limit the number of listings per player.
- Log trades of rare or shiny creatures.
- Consider a "protected" tier of rare creatures that cannot be sold for coins but can be traded for items or other creatures.

If you sell creatures to players through the server, charge a lot and use limited stock.

Rare and shiny hunting

Rare spawns are the endgame for many players. Treat them as a controlled part of the economy:

- Do not add a way to buy rare creatures cheaply.
- Be strict about duplication and mass-farming.
- Events with rare prizes are best as **time-limited** and **limited stock**.
- Make sure rare drops are not tradable for huge sums of coins without a fee.

Economy mods and tools

Modpack servers need an economy mod, or a hybrid server that supports plugins. A few examples that exist at the time of writing:

- A **currency and shop mod** made for the pack (for instance, "CobbleDollars" is one popular choice)
- An **economy API mod** for server-side balances (for example "Impactor")
- A **plugin-capable hybrid** server if you want to reuse plugin tools

Always check that your chosen option supports your pack version, saves balances reliably and offers logs and admin commands. See Plugin ideas for features to look for.

Starting out

- A starter kit with a few capture balls and healing items.
- A first goal that rewards catching and battling.
- Cheap capture balls for the first hours.
- A shop that buys common drops at modest prices.

Exploits to watch

- Duplicating items or creatures
- Auto-battling NPCs overnight
- AFK catching in busy spawn areas
- Trading creatures between alts to move money
- Buying cheap creatures from the shop and selling them higher
- Selling large numbers of common creatures to the server

Checklist for Cobblemon

- Cap money from repeatable battles
- Do not buy common creatures at meaningful prices
- Use capture balls, healing and evolution items as main sinks
- Tax creature trades
- Log trades of rare and shiny creatures
- Check your pack's economy mod for logs and admin tools
- Anti-AFK for catching and battling areas

Toolkit

A health check, a weekly checklist, formulas, plugin ideas and a glossary.

Economy health check

Type in a few numbers from this week and get a plain-words verdict from Nugget. Runs in your browser; nothing is sent anywhere.

How to get the numbers

You do not need to be exact. Rough numbers give a useful answer.

NUMBER	WHERE TO FIND IT
Active players	Your plugin's player count, or logins in the last 7 days
Total money	The sum of all balances. Many economy plugins show it, or add up the top balances and estimate the rest
Money created per day	Payouts from jobs, shop sales, rewards, crates, interest and so on, averaged over the week
Money removed per day	Taxes, fees, rent, shop purchases, upgrades, cosmetics and so on, averaged over the week
Richest 10% share	Add up the top 10% of balances and divide by the total

What the verdict means

CHECK	HEALTHY	WATCH	ACT
Sinks vs faucets	80% to 120%	60% to 80%, or 120% to 150%	Under 60%, or over 150%
Money per player, week over week	Within 5%	5% to 15%	Over 15% either way
Average balance, in days of income	7 to 60 days	Under 7, or 60 to 90	Over 90 days
Richest 10% share	Under 50%	50% to 70%	Over 70%



NUGGET SAYS

Run this every week at the same time and keep the results in your sheet. One reading tells you where you are. A month of readings tells you where you are going.

Your numbers are saved in this browser only, so you can come back next week and update them.

Use the interactive Health Check on the website to run these numbers for you.

Weekly checklist

A routine for staff. Tick things off as you go. Your progress is saved in this browser.

Every day (5 minutes)

- [ ] Skim the money log for unusually large transfers or payouts
- [ ] Check the chat and reports for "I found a bug" or "that is too cheap"
- [ ] Look at the top 5 balance changes of the day
- [ ] Make sure no plugin errors mention money or economy

Every week (30 minutes)

- [ ] Write down active players and total money in the weekly sheet
- [ ] Work out money per player and compare with last week
- [ ] Add up faucets and sinks and work out the sinks vs faucets percentage
- [ ] Run the health check and save the result
- [ ] Record the median price of your basket of common items
- [ ] Review the top 10 earners and the top 10 new balances for suspicious accounts
- [ ] Check that every event or giveaway stayed inside its budget
- [ ] List what you changed this week and why

Every month (1 hour)

- [ ] Review all shop prices in the spreadsheet and fix anything out of line
- [ ] Re-run the loop test on any recipe or item you added
- [ ] Check the richest 10% share and the wealth gap
- [ ] Check that new players still reach their first goals within a session
- [ ] Review tax and fee totals and decide whether the rates still make sense
- [ ] Look at the most-used sinks and the least-used sinks
- [ ] Update the wiki or rules page with any new rates, caps or prices
- [ ] Post a short economy report for players

Before any change

- [ ] Write down the number you want to move and by how much
- [ ] Change only one lever at a time
- [ ] Announce the change in advance
- [ ] Set a date to review the result

After an incident

- [ ] Stop the faucet or feature involved
- [ ] Find who used it and how much was made
- [ ] Remove illegal gains fairly
- [ ] Fix the cause and test the fix
- [ ] Tell players what happened and what changed
- [ ] Add a note to the log so the next person can learn from it

Formulas and examples

Every calculation in this guide in one place, with worked examples you can copy into a spreadsheet.

None of this needs more than basic maths. Every formula is written so you can paste it into a spreadsheet.

Health numbers

Money per active player

```
money per player = total money / active players
```

Track this weekly. It is the most honest sign of inflation.

Weekly change in money per player

```
change = (this week per player / last week per player - 1) x 100
```

> **EXAMPLE**
> Last week: 1,000,000 coins across 100 players, so 10,000 each. This week: 1,150,000 across 105 players, so 10,952 each. Change = (10,952 / 10,000 - 1) x 100 = **+9.5%**. That is a "watch" result.

Sinks vs faucets

```
ratio = sinks per day / faucets per day x 100
```

Aim for 80% to 100% on a settled server.

Days of income

```
days of income = average balance / (faucets per day / active players)
```

Shows how many days of play it would take to earn the average balance. 7 to 60 is comfortable.

Wealth share

```
top 10% share = money held by the richest 10% / total money x 100
```

Price index

Record the median auction price of 8 to 12 common items each week. Add them up. Divide this week by your starting week and multiply by 100.

```
index = this week's basket total / first week's basket total x 100
```

An index of 100 is your baseline. 110 means prices are 10% higher.

Pricing

Price from time

`base price = hours to obtain x hourly rate`

Sell price from buy price

`sell price = buy price x 0.25 to 0.40`

Loop check

`profit per cycle = sell price of output - cost of inputs`

If profit per cycle is above zero for any chain, you have a loop.

Controlling bulk selling

Falling price per item sold

`price = base x (1 - decay) ^ items sold today`, never below a floor of 20% to 30% of base

> EXAMPLE
> Base price 10, decay 0.2% per item, floor 30% (3 coins). After 100 sales the price is 10 x 0.998^100 = 8.2. After 500 it is 10 x 0.998^500 = 3.7. After 600 it hits the floor of 3.

Daily cap with a slope

`multiplier = 1 for the first N items, then fall linearly to 0.25 by 3N, then stay at 0.25`

A simple way to explain it to players: "Full price for the first N each day. After that it drops."

Dynamic price from stock

`price = base x (target stock / current stock) ^ k`, clamped between 0.2 x base and 3 x base

`k` is how strongly the price reacts. Start with 0.3 and raise it only if prices react too slowly.

Taxes and income

Tax on a transfer

`tax = amount x rate`, rounded **up** to at least 1 coin once the amount is above your free limit

Rounding down to zero lets players dodge tax with tiny trades.

Tax drain per day

`daily drain = daily trade volume x average tax rate`

Wealth tax

`weekly tax = (balance - exempt amount) x rate`, only when the balance is above the exempt amount

> **EXAMPLE**
> Exempt amount 1,000,000. Rate 1% per week. A player with 3,000,000 pays (3,000,000 - 1,000,000) x 0.01 = 20,000. A player with 900,000 pays nothing.

Interest

Compound growth

`balance after n days = balance x (1 + daily rate) ^ n`

At 1% daily, money grows about 38 times in a year. At 0.1% daily, about 1.4 times. At 0.5% daily, about 6.2 times.

Capped interest

`interest = min(balance, cap) x rate`

Cap the balance that earns interest. That keeps it a small faucet for everyone, not a huge one for the rich.

Budgets

Faucet budget per player

`max income per hour = hourly rate x 1.5`

If a player who uses every faucet earns more than 1.5 times the planned rate, tighten something.

Event budget

`event budget = percent of daily faucets x daily faucets`

Keep events to something like 5% to 10% of a day's faucets.

Plugin and tool ideas

What kinds of plugins an economy needs, the features worth looking for and a few well-known examples. No endorsements, just starting points.

This page is **plugin-neutral**: it tells you what to look for, not what to buy. Always check that a plugin supports your server version and software before you rely on it. Plugin names, features and support change, so verify before you commit.

The building blocks

BLOCK	WHAT IT DOES	EXAMPLES TO LOOK AT
Economy core	Stores balances and lets other plugins use money	Vault (and compatible forks), EssentialsX economy, standalone economy plugins
Admin shop	Server-run buy and sell prices	ShopGUI+, EconomyShopGUI, DynamicShop
Player shops	Players run shops in the world or by GUI	ChestShop, QuickShop forks
Auction house	Listings, bids, search	Many auction plugins exist. Pick one with fees and expiry
Jobs	Pay for actions	Jobs Reborn and similar
Banks and interest	Savings, tiers, interest	Several bank plugins
Land and rent	Plots, claims, upkeep	GriefPrevention, Towny, Lands and plot plugins
Multi-currency	Extra currencies	CoinsEngine and similar
Logging and rollback	Tracks who did what	CoreProtect and similar
Placeholders and display	Show balances and stats	PlaceholderAPI and its expansions
Permissions	Controls who can do what	LuckPerms
Anti-cheat and AFK	Stops auto-clickers and idle income	An anti-cheat plus an AFK plugin
Analytics and reporting	Money tracking and reports	Some plugins, or your own export and spreadsheet

These are examples, not recommendations. Choose by features and by how active the author is.

What to look for in an economy plugin

- **Works with the standard economy interface** so other plugins can pay and charge.
- **Reliable storage.** A database option and safe saves. Losing balances is the worst bug.
- **Logging.** Every transaction recorded with who, what and when.
- **Transaction safety.** Handles negative numbers, huge numbers and doing two things at once.
- **Admin tools.** Set, give, take, reset, and a clear audit trail.
- **Offline balances.** Players can be paid or charged while offline.
- **Fast.** No lag when many players trade.
- **Active updates** for your server version.

What to look for in a shop plugin

- Separate **buy** and **sell** prices
- **Daily limits**, stock or falling prices
- **Price changes without restart**
- **Categories and search**
- **Permission-based limits** (so ranks can see different shops)
- Clear **sell-all** and **sell-hand** features with limits
- A way to **exclude** certain items (like machine output)
- Logging of sales

What to look for in an auction plugin

- Listing and sale **fees**
- **Listing limits** and **expiry**
- **Min and max** prices, or a price floor
- Search, sort and categories
- Offline sales: sellers get paid even when away
- Logging, and a way to remove listings

What to look for in a jobs plugin

- Configurable **pay per action**, with caps
- **Diminishing returns** or daily limits
- An **anti-AFK** and anti-farm option (for example ignoring spawner mobs)
- Level progression with rising costs
- Permissions per job

Taxes and fees

Some economy and shop plugins have built-in transfer taxes or fees. If yours do not, you can:

- Use a plugin that supports transaction fees
- Take fees in shop and auction plugins
- Use a small custom plugin or script
- Apply rent and upkeep through your land plugin

Check that fees apply to **every** trade path, or players will use the one that has none.

Modpack servers

For a Fabric or NeoForge pack, plugin lists do not apply. Look for **mod equivalents**, such as economy API mods, currency mods and shop mods, or use a hybrid server that supports plugins. See Cobblemon.

Setup advice

- Keep the number of economy plugins small. Each one is another thing to balance.
- Install on a test server first and run the loop test.
- Back up economy data daily.
- Keep a list of every plugin that creates or removes money, in one document.
- Write the permissions down so staff know who can do what.

> **BACK UP BEFORE UPDATES**
> Updating an economy plugin can change how it stores data. Back up balances before every update and test on a copy first.

Glossary

Every economy word used in this guide, in plain language.

TERM	MEANING
Active player	A player who logged in during the period you are measuring, usually the past 7 days
Admin shop	A server-run shop where players buy from and sell to the server
AFK	Away from keyboard. A player who is idle but still earning
Alt account	A second account owned by the same person
Arbitrage	Buying something in one place and selling it for more in another
Auction house	A player market where items are listed for sale
Basket	A fixed list of common items used to measure price changes
Burn	Remove coins from the game permanently
Cap	A limit on how much a player can earn or sell in a period
Catch-up	Mechanics that help new players close the gap to veterans
Currency reform	Changing the scale of money, such as dividing all balances and prices by 10
Deflation	Money becomes scarce and prices fall, or players cannot afford things
Diminishing returns	Each extra action earns a bit less than the one before
Dupe	A bug that copies items or money
Exploit	Using a bug or loophole to gain an unfair advantage
Faucet	Anything that creates new coins
Floor and ceiling	The lowest and highest price an item is allowed to have
Hoarding	Holding large amounts of money or items without using them
Hourly rate	How much an hour of normal play should earn
Inflation	The same item costs more and more coins over time
Loop	A chain of trades or crafts that ends with more coins than it started with
Money supply	All the coins that exist at a given moment
Monopoly	One player controlling most of a market
Price index	A single number that tracks the average price of the basket over time
Recycle	Return collected coins to players through events or prizes
Sink	Anything that permanently removes coins
Spread	The gap between what the shop charges and what it pays
Starter kit	Free items given to new players
Treasury	A server account that collects taxes and fees

TERM	MEANING
Velocity	How fast money changes hands
Wash trading	Two accounts trading back and forth to dodge tax or fake activity
Wealth tax	A small recurring tax on large balances